Forces have been insulted and how rather than stand to the back of the embrasure, the GOC had taken a 'stand by sitting down'. I was blissfully unaware of this raging controversy as my mobile was at home and I came to know of it only after I returned. I rang up the Chief to clarify that it was only his orders that I had followed and that there was no intention of creating any controversy. Gen Rawat was pretty cool about it. He told me not to bother; these things will happen. Especially now that I was in line to succeed him, there would be many detractors waiting to pounce and discredit me. I should just continue to do my job as I always had. He would take care of the rest. In the evening was the 'At Home', a reception hosted by the President at Rashtrapati Bhawan. Gen and Mrs Rawat and my wife and I were standing side by side when the President and the PM walked by, greeting all the guests. The President conveyed his appreciation for a well-conducted event. When the PM passed by, he said to me with a smile, '*General Sahib, kyon marwate ho*?' referring, I suppose, to the morning's incident. I looked at Gen Rawat with a rueful smile. When we got back, I recounted this incident to Isha, Amala and Simon and we all had a hearty laugh. Before going to bed, I turned to Veena and jokingly remarked, 'There go my chances of becoming Chief,' and went to sleep soundly.

With such a large garrison at Delhi, it was not only the men but the families that also had to be looked after, including their basic needs such as medical and education. The NCR also has a large population of veterans whose needs also had to be taken into account. Due to the peculiar conditions of service, with postings taking place at short intervals and at any time during the academic year, Army kids would find it difficult to get admission in the new station. Even if they did, it might involve a change in school uniform and perhaps even syllabus.

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